In the fighting that lasted but a few hours, the Rajputs, deployed along the Nam Ka Chu, had 282 of their 500-odd men killed. Most of the others were wounded and captured.

Once the firing stopped, the bunkers and crawl trenches would become tombs for the dead. The next morning, not only the Indian casualties, even the Chinese dead were covered with stones and left where they had fallen.

In 1989, an Intelligence officer of an infantry battalion led a patrol into the Nam Ka Chu Valley, the first after the inglorious decimation of the Indian Army twenty-seven years ago. ‘There were skeletons everywhere, and we dug out quite a few—especially in the vicinity of Bridge 3 and 4, Temporary and Log Bridge. All the dog tags we found belonged to the dead from 2 Rajput, for they started with the serial number “29”. Some were probably Chinese casualties, but we had no way of knowing. There was nothing much that we could do—we just stacked them together, poured kerosene on them, saluted and cremated them. Wherever we dug, we found skeletons. Very few could have survived the carnage.’

♦

But some did survive, simply refusing to die. Subedar Dashrath Singh is today in his late nineties, having served the latter half of his life as the ADC (aide-de-camp) to the Maharaja of Varanasi. Of all the stories of the survivors, his is one of the most incredible. When the JCO finally went down, he had been hit twenty-eight times in the stomach.

‘I had no idea how many bullets had hit me,’ recalls Dashrath, ‘all I knew through the day and then the night was the bitter cold and the maddening thirst. I kept thinking if only the officers had let us deploy on the slopes behind us with just an early warning element at the river, we would have killed many more afeemchis [opium smokers, a derogatory term for the Chinese that was in vogue among the Indians].’

When the Chinese started sifting through the dead and wounded the next morning, Dashrath Singh was, amazingly, still alive, drifting in and out of consciousness. He was placed on a stretcher and laid out along with the others, both Indian and Chinese, who were still breathing. Suddenly, he was aware of a Chinese nurse bending over him. Obviously tasked with assessing the severity of their wounds, the woman had the power of life and death over the hapless men. Speaking to Dashrath Singh in fluent Hindi, she